



EVERY YEAR THOUSANDS OF HINDUS make the journey to Varanasi on the banks of the Ganges River. Many plan to live out their final days and die in this holy city. They believe that when, after death, they are cremated and their ashes scattered on the river they will finally escape the cycle of death and rebirth and attain eternal peace. At dawn, the faithful descend to the waterfront down flights of stone steps known as *ghats*. They practice meditation and yoga, make offerings, and bathe in the holy waters.

